



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

does free
will explain
all evil?

If Swinburne is right, the “free will defense” should be called the

“free will and genuine responsibility defense.”

But this addition to the free will defense gives rise to a puzzle. One way to bring out the puzzle is to ask: Can God do evil?

The standard answer to this question is that God cannot; that God is not just good, but **necessarily** good.

But suppose that this is right. This makes it somewhat mysterious why it should be so important that we have the ability to bring about evil. If God does not have this ability, and God is morally perfect, why should it be so important for us to have this ability? And it must be **very** important, given the amount of suffering which it has caused.

Summing up so far: we have seen that free will promises to explain how there could be evil in a world with an omnipotent and perfectly good God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumptions:

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good



the ability
to harm others
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A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

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**Free will
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Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.